

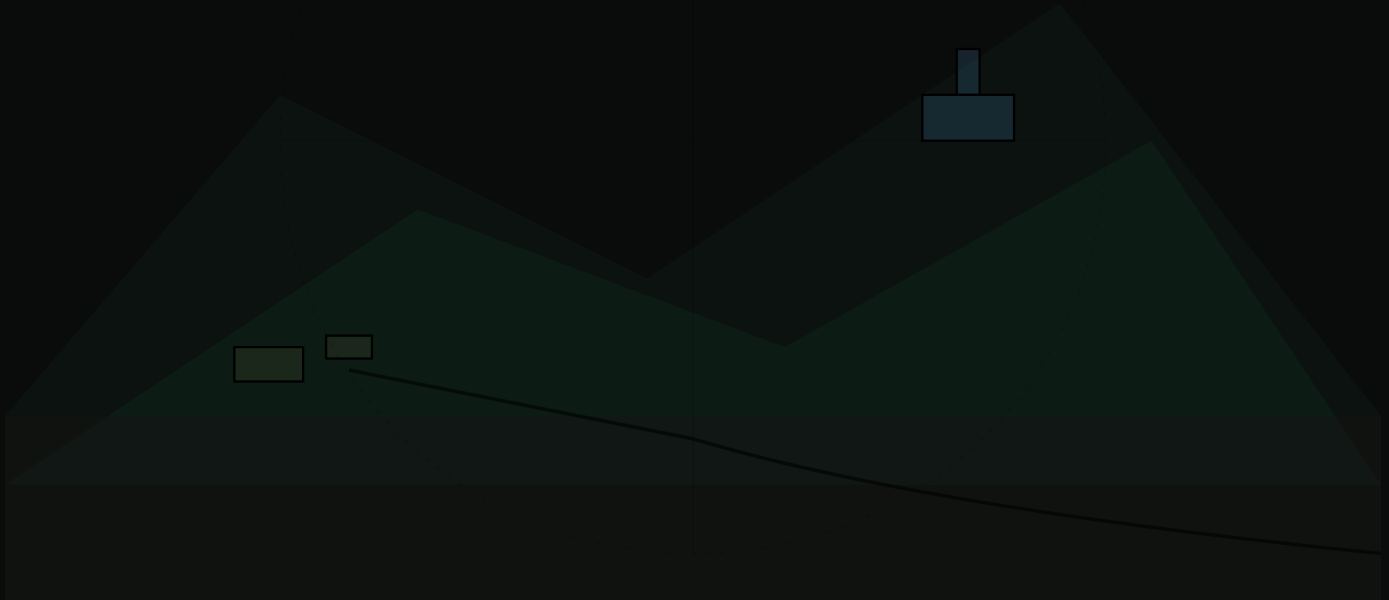
BRITISH EXPANSION IN THE FRONTIER

“When an empire reached the mountains, authority became a question of distance, negotiation and resistance.”

British expansion into the frontier was not a single event. It was a process. Political boundaries changed. New administrations appeared. Roads and military posts extended state power. Political agents negotiated with tribal leaders. Military expeditions followed disputes and resistance. Some communities accepted agreements. Others resisted. And throughout the process, the mountains remained a powerful constraint on imperial authority. For Orakzai communities, the arrival of British power did not simply replace one government with another. It changed the relationship between land, tribe, administration, security and political authority. The frontier became increasingly documented, regulated and contested. A new political order was taking shape.

BRITISH EXPANSION IN THE FRONTIER

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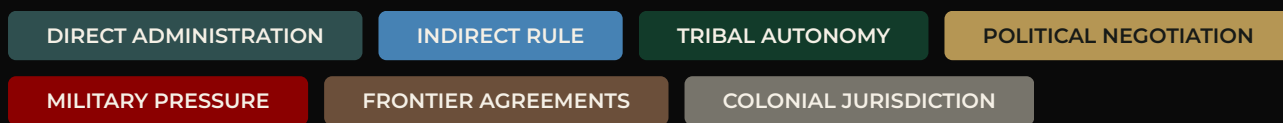
"A conceptual model of the imperial frontier: where administrative roads meet the mountain homeland."

WHAT WAS "THE FRONTIER"?

The concept of the "frontier" was perceived differently depending on the observer. For British administrators, it was a security boundary and an administrative edge—a political buffer designed to protect the plains of Punjab and manage trade routes. For the Orakzai and neighboring tribes, the same terrain was their homeland (*Watan*), a network of ancestral villages, grazing lands, and defensive valleys. This divergence in perspective defined the nature of colonial-tribal interaction.



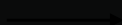
“The conflicting definitions of frontier territory between the state and the community.”



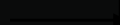
THE ANNEXATION OF PUNJAB (1849)

The formal arrival of British power on the Orakzai border followed the 1849 annexation of Punjab. After the fall of the Sikh Empire, the British inherited the frontier districts, including Kohat and Peshawar. This did not mean immediate control over the tribal hills; instead, it created a new "Close Border Policy" where the British attempted to manage the frontier from the plains, leading to a long period of negotiation and friction with the mountain tribes.⁴

SIKH EMPIRE



2nd ANGLO-SIKH WAR



ANNEXATION OF PUNJAB

(New Frontier Context, 1849)

“The political transition leading to British arrival on the Orakzai frontier.”

DIRECT VS INDIRECT CONTROL

British frontier policy was characterized by a distinction between direct and indirect control. In the settled districts, the state established courts, taxation, and regular bureaucracy. In the

tribal hills, however, the British employed "Indirect Frontier Management," relying on Political Agents, tribal intermediaries (*Maliks*), and allowances to maintain order and secure roads. This system allowed for a degree of tribal autonomy while exerting state influence through negotiation and patronage.²

Direct Administration

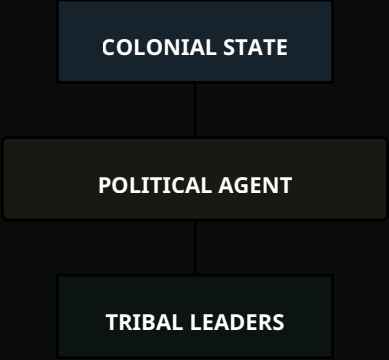
Regular officials, courts, taxation, and policing in the settled plains (e.g., Kohat district).

Indirect Management

Political Agents, subsidies, and tribal Jirgas in the mountain territories (e.g., Orakzai hills).

THE ROLE OF POLITICAL AGENTS

The Political Agent served as the primary link between the colonial state and the tribes. Their role was multifaceted: they were negotiators, intelligence gatherers, and mediators who implemented frontier policy through personal relationships with tribal leaders. This administrative structure was not an indigenous institution but a colonial tool designed to project power into autonomous zones without the cost of full annexation.²

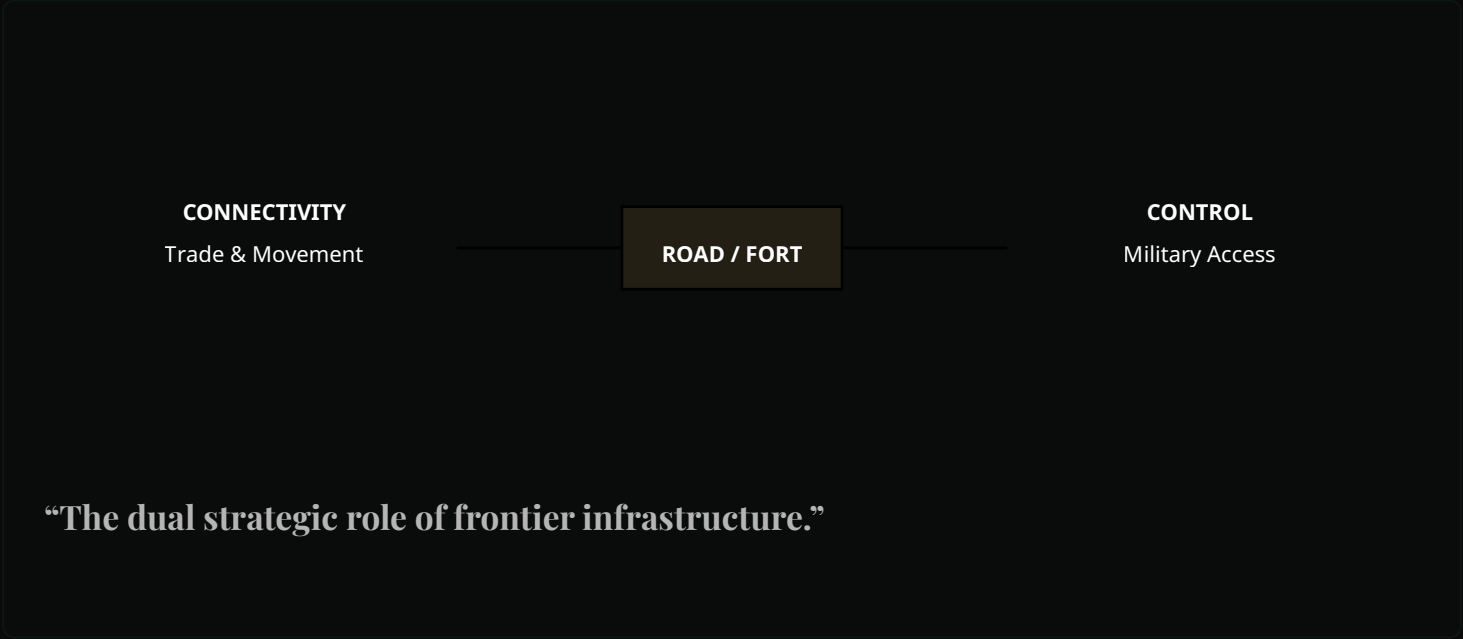


“The hierarchy of colonial frontier administration and negotiation.”

INFRASTRUCTURE: ROADS AND FORTS

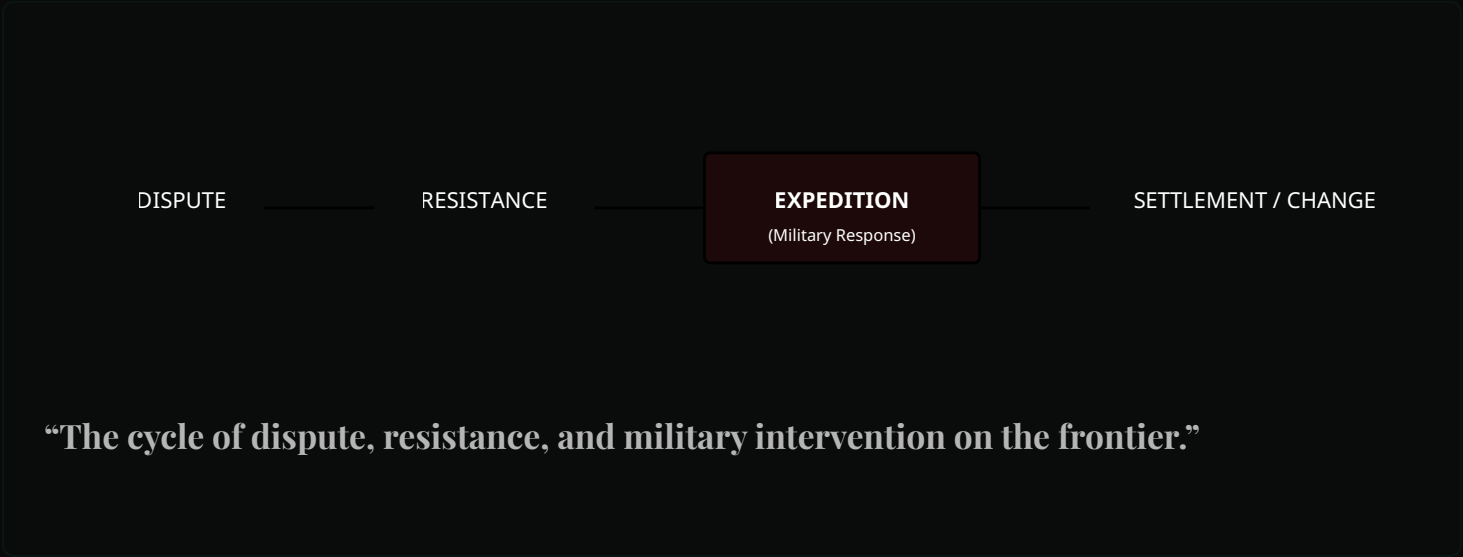
The construction of roads and frontier posts was a key element of British expansion. Infrastructure served a dual role: it provided connectivity for trade and movement, but more importantly, it allowed for military access and administrative control. Key forts on the Samana

Range, such as Fort Lockhart and Fort Gulistan, served as strategic eyes overlooking the Orakzai valleys, symbolizing the physical extension of imperial authority into the hills.³



MILITARY EXPEDITIONS AND RESISTANCE

When negotiations failed or tribal raids occurred, the British launched punitive military expeditions. These were designed to enforce collective responsibility and punish entire tribal sections for the actions of individuals. The Orakzai territory was the object of several major campaigns, most notably the 1891 Miranzai Expedition and the massive 1897 Tirah Expedition. These events were characterized by fierce tribal resistance and a massive concentration of colonial troops, leaving a lasting impact on tribal memory and regional stability.^{1 5}



AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

The history of the British frontier is often told as a story of maps and military strategy. But for those who lived in the Orakzai hills, it was a story of survival. The expansion of empire brought new technologies and new laws, but it also brought a profound challenge to the ancient autonomy of the tribes. Our ancestors did not simply watch the frontier take shape; they negotiated with it, fought against it, and ultimately adapted to it. The forts on the Samana Range still stand as reminders of a time when the mountains were the site of a great political struggle—a struggle that shaped the modern world we live in today.

“THE MOUNTAINS REMAINED THE FINAL WORD.”

AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS
